Be the Candidate They Notice

What tech companies look for, and how community gets you there

Som (Someshwaran Mohan Kumar), Senior Developer Advocate, Elastic

DevKada MERGE & SYNC, October 24, 2026





Mabuhay, Manila!

*Welcome everyone



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Who Am I?

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Senior Developer Advocate, Elastic



LinkedIn

Let's make this interactive?

Make a `promise( )`

***Type 'yes' in the chat**

Quick Poll! Reply in Chat

1 **Who graduated this year, or will next year?**

Quick Poll! Reply in Chat

1. Who graduated this year, or will next year?

2. Who has applied to 10+ jobs and heard nothing?

I Didn't Start Here Either

Elasticsearch Support

Fixing other people's broken clusters

I Didn't Start Here Either

Elasticsearch Support → **Building in public**

Fixing other people's broken clusters

Open source (Postal), blogs, talks

I Didn't Start Here Either



*Support was my side door. Side doors count.

Elastic: The Search AI Company

Search	Observability	Security
Find the right thing in a lot of data	See why an app is slow or broken	Spot threats in your logs

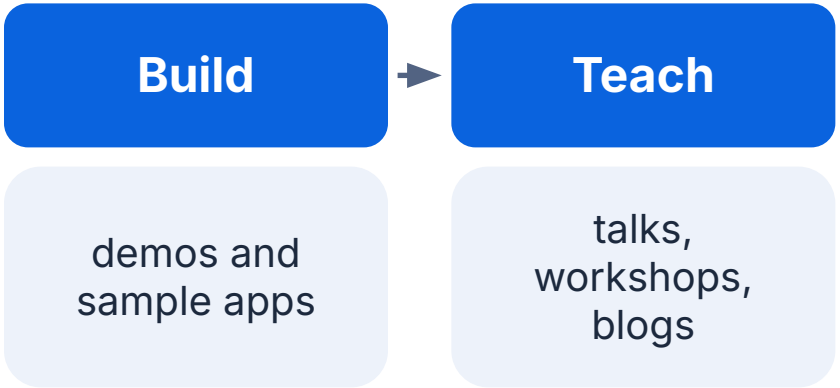
*One platform, built on open source Elasticsearch

So, What Does a Developer Advocate Do?

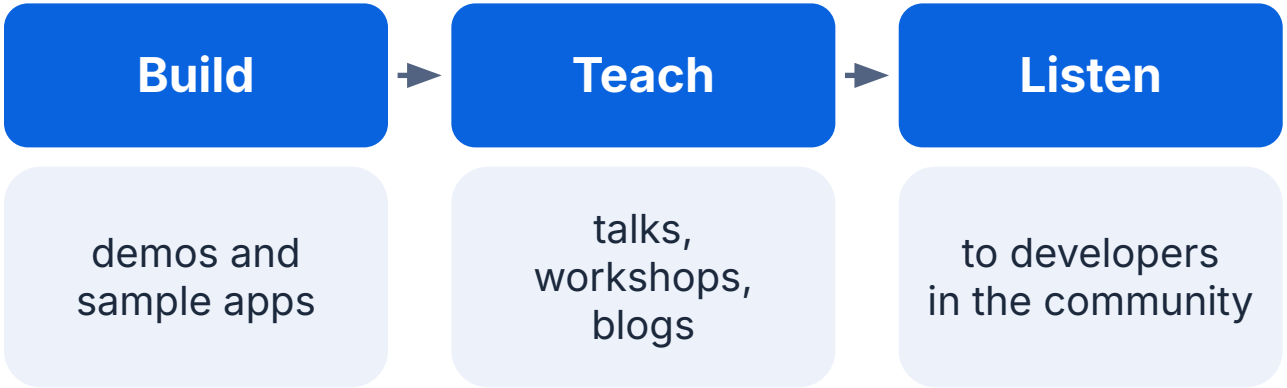
Build

demos and sample apps

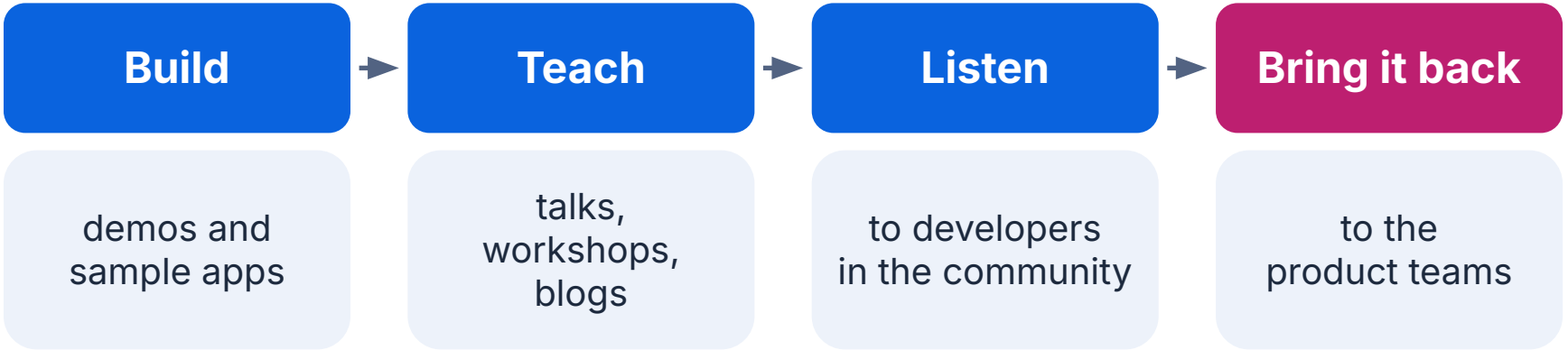
So, What Does a Developer Advocate Do?



So, What Does a Developer Advocate Do?



So, What Does a Developer Advocate Do?



*Half engineer, half teacher

It Started With a Recipe App

A developer built search for his wife's recipes.

That side project became Elasticsearch.

```
GET /

{
  ...
  "tagline":
  "You Know, for Search"
}
```

***Side projects become companies**

Distributed by Design

Many time zones	Async by default	Writing first
Teammates you may never meet in person	Work moves while you sleep	Docs, issues and PRs carry the decisions

*If you can explain it in writing, you can work from anywhere

What Companies Look For

Entry Level. 3+ Years Experience.



*We've all seen this job post

1. Proof Over Claims

~~Skills: React, Python, Docker, Kubernetes, AWS, ML, Go, Rust...~~

claims

Built a job board with search.
Live link. README. 3 real users.

proof

***One link that works beats twelve keywords**

2. Fundamentals Outlast Tools

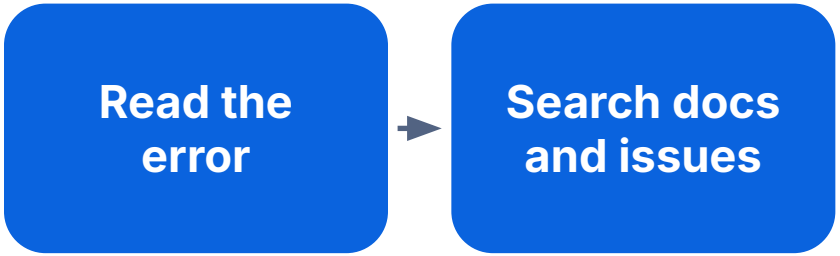
Changes every year	Stays the same
frameworks, libraries, the AI tool of the month	HTTP, databases, Linux, reading logs

***Learn the layer under the tool**

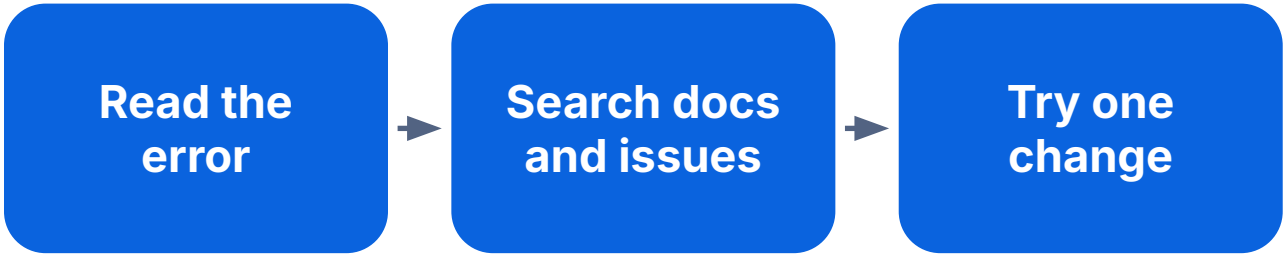
3. Can You Get Unstuck?

Read the error

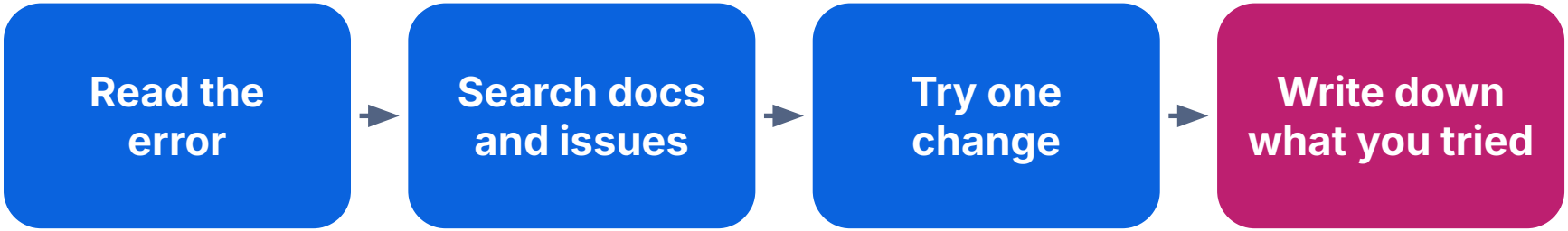
3. Can You Get Unstuck?



3. Can You Get Unstuck?



3. Can You Get Unstuck?



*"I tried X and Y, here's what I saw" is a hireable sentence

4. Writing Is the Job

"it's not working
pls help"

```
Search returns 0 hits after upgrade
Steps: index 3 docs, run match query
Expected: 3 hits
Tried: _refresh, checked mapping
```

***Teams read your work before they meet you**

5. AI Fluency, With Judgment

Use AI to go faster

Explain every line it wrote for you

*Interviewers will ask: why this line?

What Companies Look For

1. **Proof over claims**

What Companies Look For

1. Proof over claims
2. Fundamentals that outlast tools

What Companies Look For

1. Proof over claims
2. Fundamentals that outlast tools
3. Getting unstuck on your own

What Companies Look For

1. Proof over claims
2. Fundamentals that outlast tools
3. Getting unstuck on your own
4. Clear writing

What Companies Look For

1. Proof over claims
2. Fundamentals that outlast tools
3. Getting unstuck on your own
4. Clear writing
5. AI fluency, with judgment

Community Is the Shortcut

Bayanihan



*Nobody moves the house alone

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The Community Ladder

Attend

show up

The Community Ladder

Attend

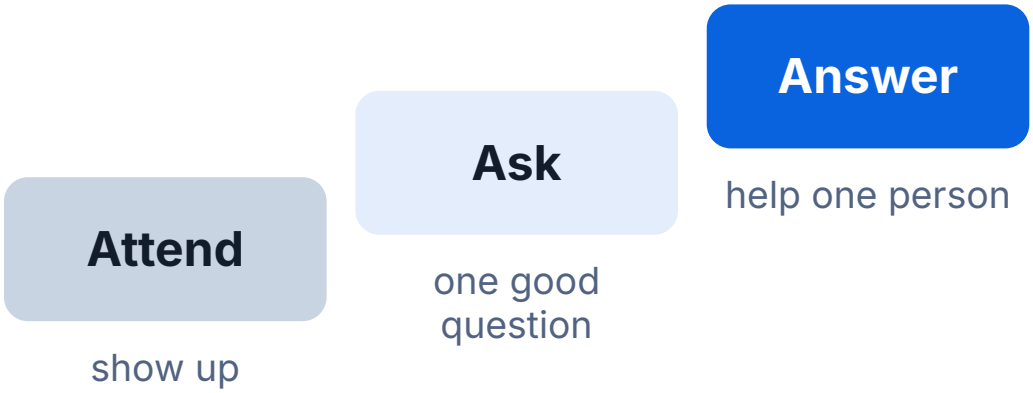
show up

Ask

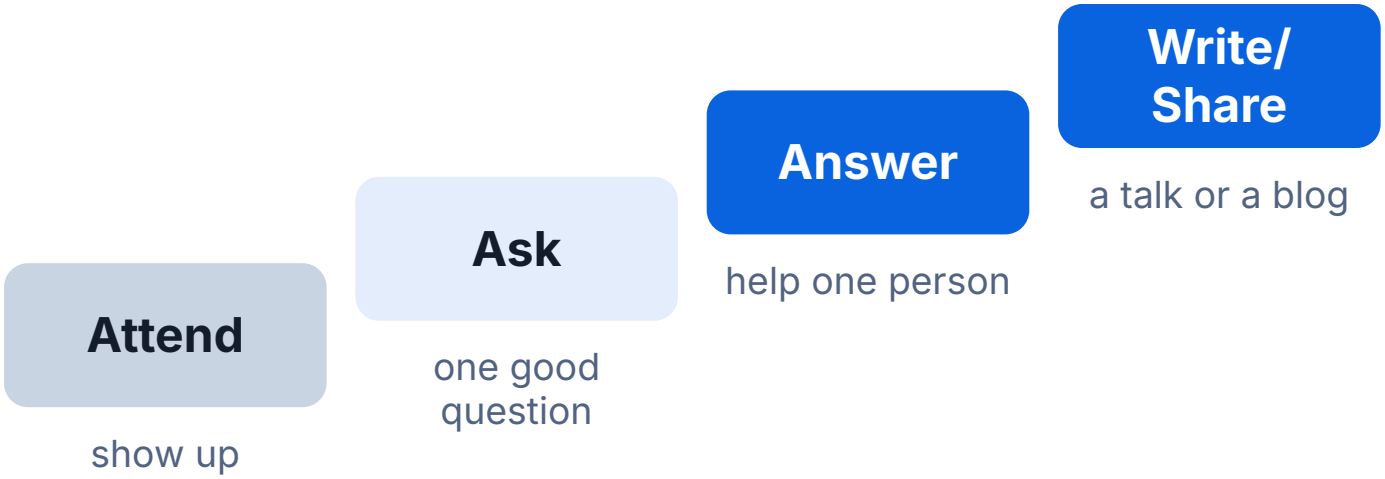
one good question

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The Community Ladder

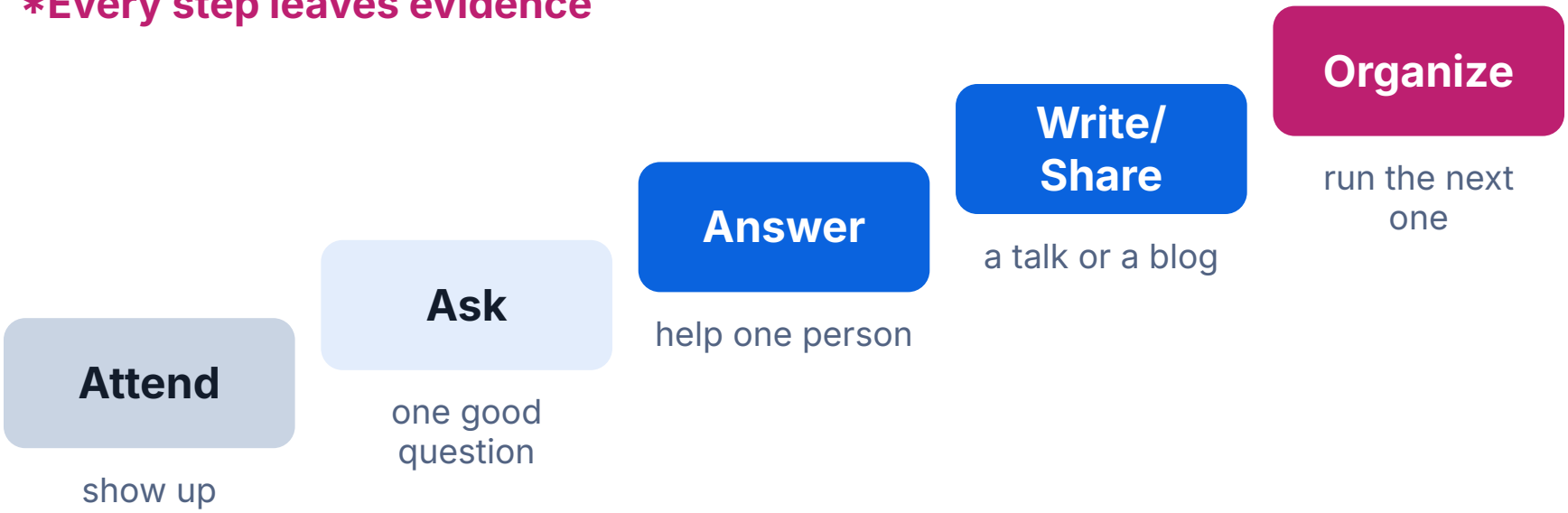


The Community Ladder



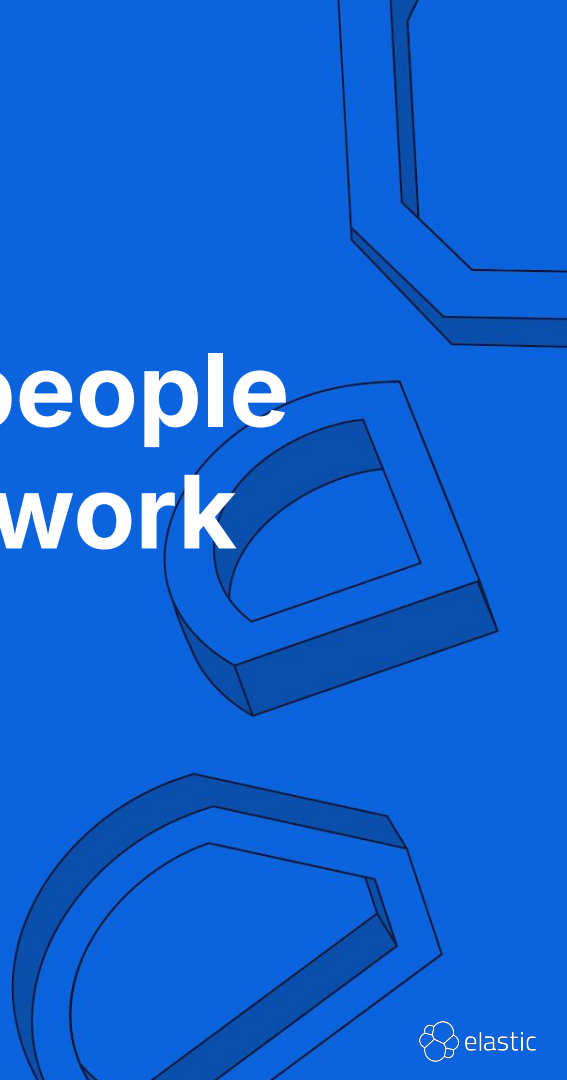
The Community Ladder

*Every step leaves evidence



Referrals come from people who have seen your work

*Community is where they see it



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Your 3-Minute Pitch

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Your 3-Minute Pitch

1. I'm ____, and I like building ____.

Your 3-Minute Pitch

1. I'm ____, and I like building ____.
2. I built ____ to solve ____.

Your 3-Minute Pitch

1. I'm ____, and I like building ____.
2. I built ____ to solve ____.
3. The hardest part was ____. Here's how I fixed it.

Your 3-Minute Pitch

1. I'm ____, and I like building ____.
2. I built ____ to solve ____.
3. The hardest part was ____. Here's how I fixed it.
4. I'm looking for ____.

*One story beats a list of skills

Come Say Hi: Elastic Meetup, Manila

Last one: Elastic Agentic Meetup
Pasig, September 2026

Next one: date coming soon

Step 1 on the ladder: Attend

***Bring a friend. Bring a question.**

Take Out Your Phones



My blog



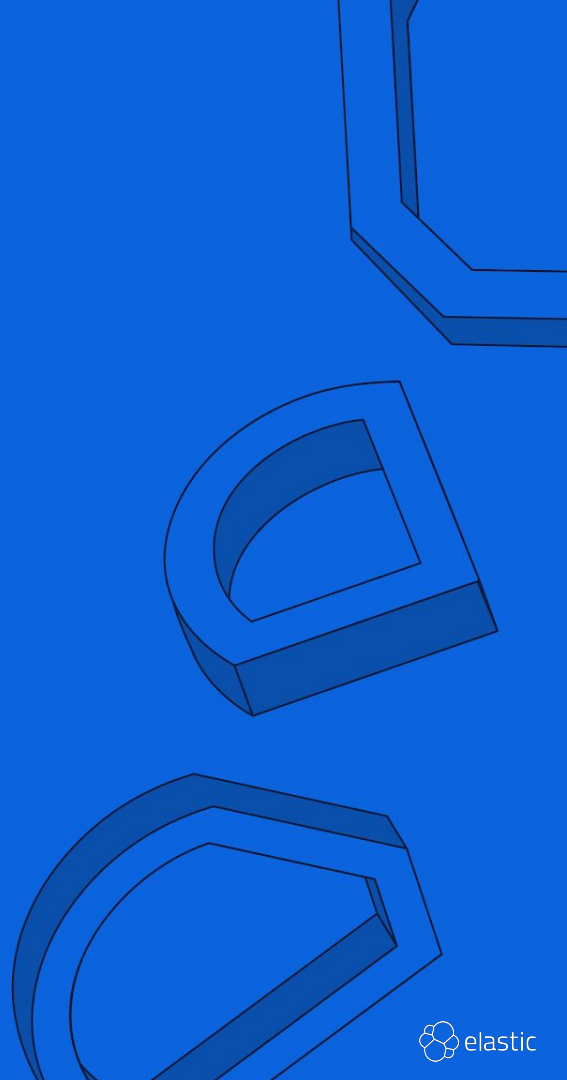
Elastic community



Elastic careers

Questions?

*Ask in the chat or unmute



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Maraming salamat!

*See you in the pitch rooms

